

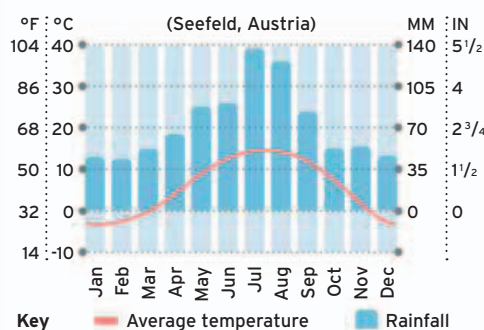
LOCATION

The Alps cover 11 percent of Europe's land area, including most of Austria and Switzerland.



CLIMATE

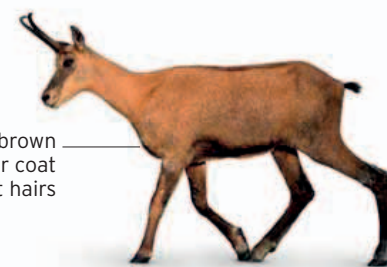
Mountains above 9,840 ft (3,000 m) sustain year-round glaciers, while summer valley temperatures routinely exceed 86°F (30°C).



Alpine chamois

Rupicapra rupicapra

tawny-brown summer coat with short hairs



Agility is the trademark of the Alpine chamois—an adaptation to its rugged mountainous environment and a crucial survival skill when pursued by predators such as lynxes and wolves. A chamois' hooves provide maximum traction on slippery rocks, and even in snow-covered terrain, it can run, sure-footed, at speeds of up to 30 mph (50 km/h), leap upwards of 7 ft (2.1 m), and span 20 ft (6 m) in a single bound.

Lethal headgear

Both sexes have vertical horns ending in a sharp, hook-like curve, although the horns are slightly thicker in males. As well as wielding these against predators, males use their horns to fight each other for access to females. Unlike other hooved mammals that engage in head-to-head combat, male chamois attack each other's undersides and flanks, often with fatal consequences.

- ↔ 4 ft (1.2 m)
- ⚖ 55–132 lb (25–60 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Grasses, forbs, leaves
- 🏠



C. to S. Europe

A newborn chamois can stand minutes after birth, ready to follow its mother

◁ MOUNTAINEERING EXPERT

The chamois' thick winter coat provides excellent insulation. Their hooves have a thin, hard edge and softer, more pliable soles for grip, so they can negotiate the steepest, iciest terrain.



LOSS OF VARIETY

The alpine lakes are home to several subspecies of whitefish, which spawn in different levels of the lakes. Because fertilizer run-off has led to algal blooms, some of the subspecies have interbred and the whitefish diversity has declined.

WHITEFISH

